Make the conference yours

The Conference Playbook

Playbook + Workbook

One worthwhile opportunity.
One realistic alternative.
A useful next move.

Read the nine guides, use the writing space that helps, and personalize the four message templates. You can use this workbook without an account or a saved plan.

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Internal review edition. Examples are fictional; they do not confirm a current role, grant, appointment or event program. Verify the current edition, eligibility, access and timing through official sources.

Official source finder: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b99814aac23eb6f256f0df4

Is this conference worth it?

Know whether to go, go only if funded, wait, or skip - and why.

01 Name your main goal. Recruiting, learning, people or sharing a project may each make a different event worthwhile.

02 Find the actual opportunity. Identify a relevant role, session or community using current organizer sources; do not count a hopeful introduction as confirmed access.

03 Compare total cost and timing. Registration is only one cost. Use the funding worksheet for detailed cash/reimbursement calculations.

04 Compare one alternative. A local gathering, online program or later conference may meet the same goal with less expense or pressure.

How to make the decision without guessing

1. Write one useful outcome: understand a technical topic, explore eligible roles, meet builders, or share a project. Include a non-job outcome if recruiting is your main aim.
2. Look for evidence on the current edition's official website: find two relevant roles, sessions or communities. Check pass and registration rules; unknown access remains Needs checking.
3. Estimate full costs: ticket, travel, accommodation, local transport, food, care/accessibility expenses and buffer. Separate confirmed from pending funding and upfront cash from later reimbursement.
4. Compare a realistic next-best choice: local event, online session, campus fair, another conference or postponing.
5. Record a conditional decision: Go / Go only if funded / Wait and prepare / Skip this edition. School year is not a pass/fail score.
6. Choose a next action; if already registered, evaluate remaining spend rather than revisiting sunk costs.

Fictional example - Jordan's fictional attendance decision
Jordan wants to explore 2027 SWE opportunities and data reliability. The trip totals USD 1,200; up to USD 400 may be reimbursed later and USD 300 is pending. With a fictional USD 1,300 safe upfront limit, Jordan can proceed conditionally. With only USD 900 available, the better choice is funding or a local alternative. No universal readiness score is implied.

Optional · Worth-it snapshot

Event / main outcome / source / estimated total / cash limit / funding certainty / Go, funded-only, wait or skip / next action.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b998117a837ef093afa8acf

How can I fund my trip?

Know what support to request, what remains uncertain, and whether you can cover costs when they are due.

01 Price the entire trip. Include registration, travel, taxes/fees, meals, local transport, care/access needs and a buffer.

02 Find realistic funding routes. Check the organizer, university, student organization, employer or relevant community - not just scholarship roundups.

03 Read the funding terms. Eligibility, what is covered, deadlines, reimbursement timing, receipts, obligations, cancellation and stacking rules.

04 Separate final cost from cash due now. Do not count pending grants as available or future reimbursements as cash in hand.

Where to look and how to ask

1. Build a cost table: amount, currency, upfront payer, due date, refund rules, confirmed coverage, reimbursement date. Compute final net and maximum upfront cash separately.

2. Search the current organizer's scholarship, travel grant, volunteer, speaker or ambassador pages; check the current edition, deadline and restrictions.

3. Search campus/employer routes for "conference travel grant," "professional development funding," "department travel reimbursement," and "student government funding." Ask relevant departments, advisers, student affairs, club finance chairs or employer contacts about the real process.

4. For each lead, check eligibility, covered expenses, who books, whether cash arrives in advance, receipts, reporting duties, combinations and cancellation terms. Save a public source, deadline time zone, status and next action.

5. Request a specific amount: event/dates, concrete learning or career goals, total budget, confirmed support, outstanding request, decision deadline, realistic share-back and required documents.

6. If you cannot safely front nonrefundable spending without a pending award, wait, reduce costs or use another option. Speaking or volunteering does not automatically cover attendance.

Fictional example - Fictional funding and cash timing
Jordan's example trip is USD 1,200. Up to USD 400 is confirmed for post-trip reimbursement if conditions are met; USD 300 remains pending. The expected final cost is USD 800 after confirmed reimbursement, but Jordan might still need USD 1,200 upfront. The pending award is not subtracted.

Optional · Funding worksheet

Source / official link / covered expense / edition and deadline / pending or confirmed / payment method / reimbursement date / next action.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b9981f7a85de426b3f4578f

What should I prepare?

Know what is confirmed, what still needs action, and where to find the answer.

01 Conference. Save ticket/registration confirmation, pass type, dates and current attendee instructions.

02 Opportunities. Profiles, job applications, scheduled meetings and event invitations may be different steps.

03 Participation. Check sessions, communities or expo access relevant to your goal - not recruiting by default.

04 Ready to talk. Prepare one true work/project story, a useful question, travel basics and a way to receive updates.

How to check each step

1. Open the current-year organizer site and your registration email. Find the portal, ticket access, check-in, instructions and real deadlines; avoid previous-year pages.

2. Recruiting, if relevant: follow the organizer's official career route, review profile/résumé as appropriate, then inspect a specific employer's own job posting for eligibility, location, application steps and role/requisition ID.

3. Apply through the required employer route if appropriate, and save the real submission receipt. A talent profile, badge scan, interest form or conversation is not necessarily an application or invitation.

4. For learning/community/project goals, use the organizer's session catalog/app and actual RSVP route; check time, venue, pass rules and accepted confirmation. Skip unrelated recruiting tasks.

5. Prepare a true 30-second story: problem -> action/decision -> result/learning -> one question. Save confirmed appointments, timezone, travel details and one backup.

Fictional example - A completed fictional access record
Jordan's example: conference registration Confirmed; Talent Network Profile complete; employer application Submitted in a simulated case; private gathering Requested - not confirmed. Each has its own recorded source and status. No actual 2026 application or invitation is claimed.

Optional · Access checklist

Item / public official source or private confirmation / self-reported status / next action. Use To do, Submitted, Confirmed by me, Waitlisted, Not needed or Needs checking.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b998181bc61ef43ab6e7933

What should I prioritize?

Choose one worthwhile opportunity and one realistic alternative.

01 Choose a goal. Recruiting, learning, community or building lead to different priorities.

02 Find two real options. Use current organizer company/session information, then the actual employer posting, session abstract or host event page.

03 Compare fit and access. Is this relevant, available to you and worth the time it would take?

04 Choose an action. Save the best target, exact source, one question or next step, and a backup.

How to research and rank a target

1. Start with the current organizer's sponsor, session, speaker or community listing. Shortlist two or three, not an exhaustive company list.

2. Recruiting: inspect a real current employer posting and capture title/ID, graduation and experience requirements, location and application route. Learning/community: use the actual abstract or RSVP and note time and access.

3. Record the public source URL, checked date, requirements, what remains unknown and why it fits. If no role/event is verified, write None confirmed yet - never invent one.

4. Rank qualitatively: A is close to your goal with an executable next step; B is a useful alternative; C is optional. Sponsor prestige does not imply hiring or access.

5. Choose a specific question/action, expected queue/travel cost, appointment confirmation if any and fallback. A booth visit does not replace a required official application.

Fictional example - Fictional recruiting and builder choices
Jordan compares an invented Cedar Labs SWE internship, simulated ID CL-DEMO-27, with a possible data workshop; expo access stays unknown. Sam, a fictional AFROTECH builder, seeks a relevant founder/community conversation about coordination failure, without needing a résumé-upload task.

Optional · Compare priorities

Target / public source URL or Not verified / fit / access / one question / first action / backup.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b998184a8f5cede250b5bf0

Where should I spend my time?

Make a realistic day plan you can revise when sessions, queues or energy change.

01 Protect confirmed commitments. Save actual start/end time, local time zone, location, access status and source.

02 Choose a few flexible priorities. Each needs a reason: role, speaker, learning question or community.

03 Leave space for travel and rest. Account for movement between rooms, queues, meals and breaks.

04 Choose a backup. If a booth is busy or an activity is full, choose a useful alternative.

How to build and adjust a day plan

1. Check the current organizer agenda and map; record the local timezone, current room/venue details and pass restrictions. Old agendas and unapproved RSVPs are not fixed commitments.
2. Block immovable items: confirmed meetings, sessions with actual access, speaking/volunteer duties and transport. Save local date/time, place, source or safe redacted reference and travel buffer.
3. Add up to three flexible priorities with goal, source, current access status and next action. Nonrecruiting plans do not need job tasks.
4. Compare observed queue length and remaining travel time against your next fixed appointment, energy and alternative. No universal queue cutoff or predicted availability.
5. Choose Keep / Swap / Skip / Verify access first, state what changes and choose a backup. Requested invitations never become fixed commitments by being on a draft calendar.
6. Afterward, note one useful insight or promise and a suitable follow-up action if any.

Fictional example - Fictional queue versus confirmed appointment
On fictional Oct 29, Jordan has an 11:15 AM workshop in "Demo Room C" with simulated access. At 10:30 AM an estimated 55-minute queue conflicts with Jordan's departure buffer. Jordan swaps to question preparation rather than treating an optional booth as more important. These are not actual GHC sessions or rooms.

Optional · Daily field sheet

Local date and timezone / fixed start-end, room and source / flexible targets, access and reason / travel buffer / backup / next action.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b99816d9d79d3a3a7570924

How do I start better conversations?

Have one grounded exchange you can remember and, when appropriate, continue.

01 Open with context. Who you are, what caught your attention or what you are working on - briefly, not a rehearsed autobiography.

02 Ask and listen. Match the question to a recruiter, engineer, speaker, founder or peer; follow up on the answer.

03 Close naturally. Thank them, note the useful part and propose a next step only if appropriate.

Conversation openings for different people

1. Recruiter: "I'm a May 2027 student exploring SWE roles. I found [actual role/requisition]. Is there a conference-specific application step or should I follow the posting?" A badge scan is not an interview.

2. Engineer/speaker: "Your explanation of [actual public detail] connects to [real work]. What made the team choose [specific trade-off]?"

3. Peer/organizer: "I'm exploring [shared interest]. What drew you to this community? Are there public resources you recommend?"

4. Builder/founder: "I'm testing a way to coordinate group activities. When plans fall apart, which step is hardest?" Listen before a product pitch.

5. Close with thanks and something you will genuinely investigate. A useful conversation need not yield a referral or private contact.

Fictional example - Fictional exchange
Jordan mentions a class project with inconsistent data and asks what testing trade-off mattered. Maya responds about handling conflicting records; Jordan plans to test that idea. In the fictional example, Maya offers LinkedIn and Jordan promises a project link. No real contact is implied.

Copyable prompt · No form

I noticed [specific public detail] -> I have experience with [true context] -> I am curious about [answerable question]. Afterward note one insight and any real promise.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b998132b3b7ddc3434b4bba

What else should I explore?

Find a worthwhile learning or community activity you can actually access.

01 Choose a purpose. Learn one idea, meet shared-interest peers, get project feedback or enjoy the community.

02 Find a real activity. Search the current organizer catalog/app, campus or professional groups and hosts' event pages.

03 Check entry and logistics. Public versus member-only, invitation requested versus accepted, ticket rules, time and venue.

04 Keep an alternative. Have an accessible session, conversation, meal or break if plans change.

Where to look and what to save

1. Open the current-year organizer catalog/app and organizer-linked side events. Session listings do not guarantee every pass has admission.
2. Use relevant school chapters, communities, speakers or hosts to discover events, but confirm using the actual host's current registration route.
3. Record activity name, host, audience, cost, pass restrictions, local time, venue, RSVP requested/waitlisted/accepted, and source; unknown access stays Needs checking.
4. Choose setting based on purpose, travel and energy: workshops for practice, panels for contrasting approaches, discussions for depth, socials for peers.
5. Speaking, volunteering and content coverage require separate checks of responsibilities, consent and payment/access; do not assume free travel or media privileges.

Fictional example - Fictional AFROTECH builder path
Sam wants to understand group-activity coordination. A founder gathering is merely a research lead until the official organizer and host process confirms access. If restricted, Sam switches to an accessible peer conversation or session.

Optional · Save an activity

Purpose / activity or community / public source URL / local time and venue / access status / one question or action / backup.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b9981df9cd6d33e53927521

Who should I follow up with?

Finish meaningful commitments without messaging everyone.

01 Recall what happened. Where you met and the specific topic or next step discussed.

02 Choose the right action. Official job application, promised resource, one small question or a learning experiment; messages are not always necessary.

03 Use an appropriate route. Use the contact method offered, a suitable public professional channel or the official process; do not guess private emails.

04 Track what you control. Mark an action done separately from replies, applications, interviews or offers.

How to follow through without guessing

1. Record context, actual topic, promise or instruction, offered channel and agreed timing privately; do not publicly expose personal contacts.
2. If told to apply through the employer's official portal, do that instead of inventing a recruiter email. If you promised a link, use a real appropriate route. Learning with no contact can still lead to action.
3. Draft only from real details: where you met -> accurate insight/promise -> relevant action/resource -> short close. Do not fabricate referrals or commitments.
4. Honor agreed timing; thoughtful follow-up within a day or two may help but is not a universal deadline. Record the date completed.
5. Track action done/sent, external reply, application and interview/offer as independent statuses. No reply does not invalidate a useful conversation.

Fictional example - Two fictional follow-through outcomes
Jordan has a simulated application and no direct recruiter channel, so follows the official employer process. Separately, peer Maya offered LinkedIn in the fictional case; Jordan shares a promised project link and records Sent, while Reply remains Pending. Sam has no contact route and instead experiments with a product insight.

Optional · Private commitment card

Context / promised or appropriate next action / channel or official source / due date / action status / external response. Private details are not printed by default.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b9981929326c32e721fa3ee

What should I do with what I learned?

Turn one takeaway into something you can try, without needing a public recap.

01 Choose one useful insight. A decision, trade-off, community idea or technical lesson that changed your thinking.

02 Connect it to your life. A project, role, question, community contribution or future event choice.

03 Take one action and revisit. Apply it, explore further or decide not to act; record what happened later.

How to make a post-conference review useful

1. Soon after the event, recall the original goal: what did you intend to learn, explore, contribute or experience?
2. Separate actions from outcomes: which activities really occurred, what was learned or promised, and what remains pending?
3. Choose one application: technical experiment, role research, owed resource or community share-back.
4. Revisit after a week or two: action done? Helped? Relationship continued? What remains uncertain? "Not yet" is valid.
5. Share publicly only if useful and appropriate; honor any reporting requirement and do not reveal private discussions without consent.

Fictional example - Fictional insight to action
Sam observes that people sometimes agree to group activities without setting a time. With no contact details exchanged, Sam plans a small opt-in reminder prototype and to show it to willing friends one week later. Its effectiveness is not assumed.

Optional · Insight-to-action

Original goal / observed experience / insight / action or deliberate no-action / review date / actual outcome. Public posting is optional.

Editorial source: https://app.notion.com/p/3f7b144c6b9981da9ce5c2ddc1359f18

Funding request

Check recipient, eligibility, pending versus confirmed awards, decision deadline and actual covered expenses.

Personalize every bracketed detail truthfully. This is a draft; nothing is sent.

Hi [Name],

I am requesting support to attend [Conference] because it connects directly to my goals in [role/theme].

At the conference, I plan to focus on [sessions/sponsors/communities] so I can learn more about [specific topic].

I also plan to bring the value back to [school/org/community] by [share-back plan].

Estimated cost:
- Registration: [amount]
- Travel: [amount]
- Lodging: [amount]
- Total: [amount]

Funding requested: [amount]

Thank you for considering my request,
[Name]

Your notes or changes

Pre-conference reach-out

Verify participation and real context. Make a small, flexible request; do not imply an appointment exists.

Personalize every bracketed detail truthfully. This is a draft; nothing is sent.

Hi [Name],

I saw that you may be attending [Conference] with [Company/Org]. I am a [year/stage] interested in [role/theme], and I have been following [specific team/product/session/topic].

If you are open to it, I would love to stop by during the conference or find a quick time to introduce myself.

Best,
[Name]

Your notes or changes

Same-day follow-up

Mention only what happened and use an appropriate channel. Sometimes the next action is an official application instead.

Personalize every bracketed detail truthfully. This is a draft; nothing is sent.

Hi [Name],

It was great meeting you at [booth/session/event] today. I appreciated what you shared about [specific detail from conversation].

I was especially interested in [team/product/problem] because [connection to your project, experience, or goal].

I would love to stay connected and continue learning about [specific next step or topic].

Best,
[Name]

Your notes or changes

Optional LinkedIn recap

A public recap is optional. Omit untrue or empty claims and get permission before discussing private interactions.

Personalize every bracketed detail truthfully. This is a draft; nothing is sent.

I went into [Conference] with one question:
[Question you were trying to answer]

What I learned:
1. [Insight from session/booth/conversation]
2. [Insight from sponsor/company/community]
3. [Insight about your own goals]

My next step:
[Action you are taking after the conference]

Grateful to [people/orgs/sponsors] for [specific support].

Your notes or changes

Take the useful parts with you

Your blank Field Plan

Event / edition / local dates and timezone

Main goal and conditional attendance decision

One priority / public source / access status / next action

Fixed appointment / local time / venue / confirmation

Realistic alternative / source / next action

Follow-through / appropriate route / due date

One insight / action / review date

Keep private contact details, financial figures, full drafts and token-bearing URLs out of shared copies. The site's personal Field Plan excludes them unless you explicitly opt in. Times and access are self-reported; verify changes.